

187 Measure a tree's age

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What you need

- Tape measure
- Large tree
- Pen and paper
- Calculator

Trees grow wider every year, as new wood is formed beneath the bark. This width, or “girth,” is added at different rates for different species, but you can use an average for each type to find an approximate age.



This oak tree adds about $\frac{3}{4}$ in of girth each year

1 Identify the tree you want to measure. Measure around its trunk with a tape measure about $4\frac{1}{2}$ ft (1.3 m) above the ground. Note the measurement.

2 Once you know the type of tree and its girth, use average growth rates to figure out its approximate age. Divide the girth by the growth rate.

3 The typical annual growth

rates of some common trees are: oak— $\frac{3}{4}$ in (1.5 cm); Douglas fir—3 in (7 cm); Scotch pine— $\frac{1}{2}$ in (1 cm); sycamore—1 in (2.5 cm).

188 Read some weather rings

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The width of tree rings tells you what the weather was like in times past. Narrow rings show a lack of water. Wider ones are the result of good growing conditions.

Narrow =
drought

Wide =
good

GROWTH
RINGS

